



AFP

Player to watch **FAKHAR ZAMAN**

Returning after a hiatus, Fakhar Zaman will be key. Drawing on experience, he will aim to provide strong starts and capitalise on familiar conditions. His gritty 84 in the tri-series opener against New Zealand was a confidence booster. Although he has played just one ODI since the last World Cup, the tri-series should serve as valuable preparation.

half-centuries in Ayub's absence," he said.

The recall of Khushdil Shah and Faheem Ashraf has drawn criticism. Ashraf averages 10 with the bat and 47 with the ball in 34 ODIs, last played in September 2023, while Shah, with 10 ODIs, has been absent since August 2022. Despite PCB chairman Mohsin Naqvi's defence of their inclusion, their impact remains uncertain.

A home tri-series against New Zealand and South Africa has provided preparation, though Haris Rauf's ankle injury, picked up during the series, is a concern. Pakistan's pace attack, key to three successive

away ODI series wins last year, will be led by Shaheen Shah Afridi, Naseem Shah, and Mohammad Hasnain, with Abrar Ahmed the sole spinner.

The absence of Sufiyan Muqeem and Shadab Khan raises questions about the lack of an additional spinner. How the team management navigates this challenge will be crucial.

Pakistan must raise its game after a disappointing 2023 ODI World Cup campaign. Hosting an ICC event after nearly three decades, expectations are high among fans. Now, it is up to the players to deliver.

SQUAD

Mohammad Rizwan (c), Fakhar Zaman, Babar Azam, Kamran Ghulam, Saud Shakeel, Tayyab Tahir, Faheem Ashraf, Khushdil Shah, Salman Agha, Usman Khan, Abrar Ahmed, Shaheen Shah Afridi, Mohammad Hasnain, Haris Rauf, Naseem Shah